

Word Count: ~1041

*Drowning In Thin Air*

*Lila-Josey James*

I've always wanted to jump from a great height. It's less about the dying and more about watching the Earth rush for once. As a child full of Catholic guilt, I would lay in the car during Fall excursions to Skyline Drive. Still, I'd peek out the rear window, and watch red maple leaves dance on my desire.

"If you're afraid, why do you stare?" My mother would ask.

Even if planes don't crash all that often, it only takes one to redress your relation to heights. Especially when a little girl's father is involved.

Now, I am sublimating. I'm shocked how high I've climbed fear and all. I've ascended right out of the kudzu, red clay, and whiskey. Still, every morning, I must shake out the humidity and heat of home.

"James." Tom says.

I ignore him. It's hard to feel on the 77th floor. I sip my coffee and watch the sun set. The office is emptying of the peons. The real work doesn't start until dark. Tom joins me at the window.

"I hear it's even better from the eighty seventh floor."

"Regardless, I'm just proud of what we built." I beam and mean it.

"Ah, the board would be lucky to have you." Tom rests his dry right hand on my left shoulder.

"Building anything here is a damned miracle." Tom says.

My phone interrupts. I quickly silence the phantom. There's a red five above the cat holding a phone icon.

Tom starts to smile. "Better get used to it." He glances down at my hand. His front right tooth is stained yellow with coffee and nicotine.

"How are Maddie and Tegan?" I ask.

"Maddie just started grad school, and Tegan is getting married in the fall if you can believe it."

"I still remember when she pulled the fire alarm." I say.

We both laugh. There's a moment where our eyes connect. For the first time in decades, I see past Tom's icy glare, and it almost seems kind.

"Well, J, just get used to being in the dog house." Tom says.

"Speaking of, I got those treats." I walk over to my desk with Tom in toe. "Here," I shove Tom the c-suite's coffee orders. All five are tightly packed in a cardboard container.

"Damn, Jameser you really think of everything." Tom heads towards the elevators.

I decide to leave my phone. I grab my satchel, and make for the stairs. I want to feel my blood flow, and my heart struggle. Once on the 87th floor, my thighs are numb. I walk out onto a white marble floor, adorned with cherry wood shelves. In the middle of all the bookcases, there's a circular walnut table. It's lined with coasters depicting various designs of birds with the word *Boeing* prominent.

"Are you ready Gentlemen?" I ask.

Various forms of old man walk from the pastries and coffee bar. My box sits untouched on the edge. There are still a few parfaits left. My stomach growls.

"I told you they were hungry." A faceless pudge laughs.

It starts in the back of my head. The squall travels between my shoulders. I squat down pretending to check the various wires and cords that tie us together. My hands won't stop shaking.

"Good to see there's still some work ethic left down there."

I whip up ready. There's the hum of the projector, and a few dry coughs.

"Gentlemen, I've waited my entire career for this type of summit." I begin.

I click to a slide showing the last three quarters revenue. Their doe eyes widened. A baby boomer interrupts me.

"What the hell is this supposed to be?" He asks.

"If you let me, Eric." I say.

A few members laugh.

"Tell them why we gathered." My boss gestures.

I take the time to stare at each man.

"As you know, our biggest expenditure is payroll." I close my laptop.

My boss smiles. The projection slowly fades to black. The red light of midsummer sunset fills the room in its place.

"I don't think we need to make this any longer than need be. We're letting all you go "

The air clears.

"What the fuck."

"Gentlemen," My boss stands.

"The thing is boys, if we want to reach new heights, we have to let go of the extra weight. You've all done this yourselves." With that, he walks out the room. Leaving me with a gang of men ready to pounce.

“Don’t worry,” I roll my eyes, “Your options won’t dilute.” I say.

There’s a sigh of relief as they settle back down. They still seem to be teetering on the edge of disassociation. A few are blankly looking at the skyline.

“But, then why fire us.” Eric asks.

The elevators ding. Men with walkie talkies stroll in. The tallest one looks at me and I nod. Several security officers in black suits fan around the table. They hand gestures for each unemployed bum to stand up and follow them.

“Now, if you follow these gentlemen, they’ll escort you to the street.” I say.

“Well, if we still have stock.” Tom says. “We’re getting paid to retire.”

“I didn’t finish Tom.” I say.

His massive forehead wrinkles as he sits back down. At this point, he sees the fall.

“They won’t dilute, because we’re taking them.” I say.

Still, there’s nothing. They refuse to jump.

“We’ll see you in court then.” Tom says coolly.

Finally, I push them over. My heart sucks in on itself while I watch.

“Did you not read your contracts?” I say, and head towards the elevator.

I hear the scuffing of penny loafers. Once inside, I poke my head out.

“You all were down for three quarters in a row. All shares get forfeited.”

The screaming echoes in the elevator as the door closes. I ride up to the hundredth floor. The building is swaying. As the doors open an old feeling rises up. I see my boss standing in the corner. His head is resting on the glass. He’s staring straight down. I think of red maple leaves and my father.

“Great plan sport.” He says.

“How’s your daughter by the way.” I ask.

“Oh fine, when’s the honeymoon?”